words you wanted to hear

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by asukiess

Summary

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In Gabriel's chest a slip-stitched suture comes undone. He sets his jaw, wrestles with his argument. She would—she will, he knows. They just haven't proven themselves, haven't proved much at all except for how much failure they can rack up together, him and her and all the miles between the three of them. Always harder on Nathalie, whose mind is too focused on the now, the fights she doesn't disclose to him except in clipped annotations, never saying much about her relationship with Emilie. Flashing resentment in her eyes, as if the leash that hangs from her neck noose-like and slack doesn't beg for a hand.

And he who knows her best, knows for what she longs, insatiable to the point of self-harm, is a punishment.

Notes

See the end of the work for notes

Gabriel wakes without waking, stirring slightly only pantomiming dreaming, but all of him half-asleep feels her like a second skin. A phantom limb, bent at an odd angle, the wrong angle. As far away as the sentinel door at the end of a hallway in which he can't advance.

His fingers twitch, by his side paralyzed and devastated to not be on the knob of her hip. His breath wastes itself into a void-black nothing night and not her neck and there's the familiar fear that one grave has become two and when he opens his eyes he'll be left with himself.

And that's when he hears it—

Soft rustling of their sleeping bag. Elastic slapping skin. Friction burning her whispers raw and sharpening them into something dark, something mean. Her hips buck and tug at their confined space and that's when it breaks, when *he* breaks—her fist beats on the canvas floor and what rips through the deafening silence isn't her in pleasure, her mouth so open and giving, but a hiccuped curse and a sucked in breath like sipping back blood and teeth.

When Nathalie whimpers like worrying a wound raw, Gabriel fully comes to.

Over her in a flash, his hands find her shadow's outline and confirms all her edges—here, her face wet at the cheeks and there, the heaving of her chest, the leap of her heart against its cage—then, finally, the hand darting out of her briefs, shaking terribly as if fractured. All of her, he realizes, trembling and overwarm like a fever pitching but never breaking. Sweat on her brow, something heady coating her fingertips.

From his mouth her name cleaves the night in half, dream to reality, and in response comes her apology. Breathless and breaking and barely there.

But it is, and that's assurance enough to remind him she is here; she is his.

He has her pinned by the wings, the tip of her finger twitching muscle under his grasp at her wrist. Cheap shot, to have surprised her, but his head feels like Emilie's tea stirring. Spoon and heart pounding against the china.

"I'm fine," she tries to sell but he doesn't buy it. Gabriel leaves her briefly to reach for the lantern, then hesitates. What is there to see that he does not already taste in the air or on his tongue? Perfume of her guilt and the knowledge that her eyes look the same as his, bloodshot and bagged.

Leaving them to the dark, he returns to her. Settles back to roll her over onto her back, cups her cheek and squeezes her illicit left hand still wet.

"You're doing it again," he accuses. Knowing he's right by how she instantly bristles.

"Not on purpose," she spits, embarrassment nipping at her words. "Not this time."

Once, she confessed that she'll go over an hour this way: plucking from her mind a memory of his wife, healthy with sun and a smile that doesn't fade upon seeing her. A time years ago

when the game they played was still fresh and new, when the thrill of going behind his back was able to make her wet at the thought alone.

Like this, she'll slip past her clit to circle her cunt, dipping the pad of her finger into the slick that weeps. Over and over and over around the rim until she's somewhere else, she says, dropped into a headspace that knows only one pair of rings. Circling back up to her clit, delighted sobbing breaths as she feels it throb with every neglected second that passes. Flicks quickly the air over the hood glazed with cum, replacing Emilie's breath. Her smart remarks spoken kindly, punctuated with a puff of air. How good would it feel to accidentally catch it, to remember Emilie's flicking tongue? To practice saying her name until it came out correctly, came out holy? Sliding two fingers over herself to spread the need wide, knowing it can't be filled. Works herself sick like this, lost in the pleasure of the past until she's a woman half-empty and her muscles scream with strain.

Bruised by a recent fight of theirs, she's taken to this ritual more often. Some sort of flagellation Gabriel does not understand, but has soothed her through before. He sighs, running his hands down the bare rungs of her ribs, the ladder that leads to a depth of her he prides himself in knowing so well.

When they arrive back, what does Emilie know of nights like these? When she touches Nathalie, can she divine where his hands put her back together again? She who knows best his seams, does she finger them on purpose? Worry old wounds, test Nathalie's loyalty; pick a thread and pull it loose. Let him catch it in the eye of his needle and close her back up again and wait for her to beg like she is now.

Tailor that he is, surgeon that he is not, there's electric empathy in the way he positions himself, hands at the ready over the fabric of her skin. Withered tag of her dry-rotting heart, curling at the ends and in need of repairs. Handle with care, the instructions printed say, but here they are again at this wash, this cleansing that demands the highest setting.

Holding her waist he props Nathalie's hips against his lap, opening her enough to split her legs to either side. He listens to her swallow, then begins: "Tell me what you were thinking about."

Her thighs tense. Her stomach jumps. Nathalie does not reply.

"A time I don't know about?" Gabriel tries with levity, lightly scraping his nails around to where her briefs are hemmed. Teasing, testing the tips of two fingers underneath and repeating the motion until she must be dizzy with it, the need for his hand inside her. How long had she failed before he woke? How many orgasms did she deny herself in Emilie's name? "There have to be some you still haven't indulged me with."

Her body quiets, dulls to something cold. His anxiety spikes—rather would have her shivering, hear the sharp whine she tries to gulp down every time than feel her lifeless. He growls, both his voice and fingers biting low in her belly. Her name he spits like a command, cushioning it with a tired wanting, "Let me help you."

Her continued silence he takes as an opposition, a staunch indignation to his grace, his loyalty to her. Humiliated, maybe, to have been caught. Gabriel yanks her hips to the hard

plane of his thigh and fights a smirk as he feels her clothed cunt clench at the pressure. “You’ve never been embarrassed before. So tell me. Surely it isn’t anything I haven’t already heard.”

Then Nathalie sniffles, soft and undeniably wet.

“... I can’t picture her, sir.”

Gabriel pauses. Processes her disembodied words. Their lockscreens, the picture tucked in Nathalie’s journal, the sketches by his hand that come without any musing. There is no place they go where Emilie does not follow.

“I keep dreaming of her.” Words come wearily like rain, a sleep debt unpayable by the minute gently slurring her sentences. “We’re back and we don’t leave. We don’t have to. She’s *there* and we did it, sir, we—” She sighs, a cry shuddering underneath like thunder. “It’s not her. I can’t keep her. I can’t hold onto her smile.” Her voice dampens, slows, loses hope. “Because that isn’t what she would do, is it, sir?”

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Knowing what he has to do, the remedy for her mood, his stomach drops. He’ll do it for her, of course, always, but what kindles inside is grease fire desire. Wild, untamed. A danger to hurt them both, if he isn’t careful. He steadies a breath. Notching it for resolve, for her.

“Close your eyes,” he orders.

“I’ve tried—”

“*Nathalie*.”

The tension pops and dissipates into the air of their tent, stale with recycled moments just like this. She softens under his touch, statue to clay and ready for his molding. The night still shrouds them both, but never would Gabriel forget how her eyes melt from ice to water, lace-lashes fluttering shut as she relents to this, her drowning. His thumbs press into the growing valley under her hipbone and waistband and *there*, that sound of relief from her he revels in. Still here; still his. Suspended right where he wants her.

“Good,” he coos, fleecing his earlier anger. Gliding his left hand up the length of her, he teases two fingers at the hem of her sports bra. “Do you want to show off for her?”

"*Yes,*" she breathes, offering up her chest to him. Trying, and failing, to stifle her squirming as he slips his middle finger underneath, lifting the elastic band high enough to bite at her sides. Her breathing quickens and he wonders what she's thinking about, what memory she's conjuring.

They've both developed a fixation with her breasts, Emilie and him: laving at her curves, lapping her nipples into their mouths and sucking. Both of them admitting to dropping into a haze, a headspace where when they hear her yelp they bite twice as hard to earn her scream. It was Emilie, too, who coached Nathalie from behind on how to smother his cock, hands pushing Nathalie's breasts together. He hardens at the memory, picturing Emilie's lips turning Nathalie's ear red as she whispered instructions. How Nathalie's mouth dropped open automatically, her tongue cupped and ready.

"She can't get enough of your breasts," he says, pulling the elastic tighter. Her hands must be voluntarily bound somewhere, arms thrown over her eyes, because she does not stop him as his hand raises higher.

When Nathalie's whine hitches to a whimper, he lets go.

Sharp snap slapping her sensitive skin and she cries out as her body yields to the pain, to him, her legs clamping around his thigh.

He licks his thumb as she composes herself and slowly circles her nipple, soothing away the ache. Pinches lightly, pulling just enough to toy with her, and pays attention to the moment she seems to float back down. All of her malleable in his hands. His reverence to her: giving her what she refuses herself, this dream he'll craft for her. All of it, his work.

And Gabriel is a man who takes pride in his work.

He lowers his head to gather the hot welting stripe across her chest onto his tongue. Seeding small kisses, blowing lightly to soothe her pain.

"She'll ask me to play with her like this," he says breezily, letting his words and lips catch on her skin pricking peach fuzz. Tilting his head to take her flesh into his mouth, gentle as sucking the pit from a cherry. Uncaring of the mess her leaves when he spits her out. Repeats this, ghosting the silk-smooth inside of his top lip over her nipple, but leaves her digging her heels into the floor of the tent as pauses, waits, before licking once the thin skin around it. Then lifts away without taking, sucking, biting.

"She's always thinking about you," he finishes, rolling in his bottom lip to taste her. Savoring, before continuing, "She loves you, Nathalie."

Nathalie exhales hard. Another sniffle.

"More," she says, voice thin. "Slower. Please."

And who is he to refuse her?

He rakes in a breath. "Tell me where you are, Nathalie."

A beat passes, then another, before she starts quietly, “In her bed.”

“Do you deserve that?” he asks. Smoke and mirrors. Gliding his fingers up to her mouth in lieu of waiting for her answer, he takes her words by force. Holds his knuckles under her jaw and rolls out her lower lip. “Be honest.”

“... In my bed,” Nathalie corrects, swallowing a lump Gabriel can feel mirrored in his throat. “We’re in my bed. She’s on top of me.”

“Wearing what?”

He feels her lips shift. A smile, he thinks. “A nightgown I bought for her. You’ve never seen it.”

Gabriel grounds himself, humming low as Nathalie keeps her mouth parted. Prepared, expecting. “And how is she, my wife?”

“Angry with me,” Nathalie wavers, ending her sentence by catching the tip of his thumb between her lips. Small suck, a stolen kiss. Another, then, with a hint of her tongue along his ridges. Drool begins to fuse her words. “She…”

“She what?”

“She hates me.”

He frowns, a crease forming between his brows. Wrapping this daydream thread tighter around his hand, he keeps his dog from leading. “You don’t believe that. She’s still there, isn’t that right? Under her thumb?”

Nathalie’s response slips out in a half-moan as he enters her slowly, pushing inside where everything is damned. All of her tears, all that which she keeps unsaid, clogged and needing release. He touches her soft damp tongue and pets, coaxing it all out.

“She’s willing to listen to you.” His voice is silk-smooth, quiet and all hers. “She wants you so bad, Nathalie. You can feel it.” His right hand grabs at her hip, fingertips sinking into the swell of her ass, and she in turn sets her teeth on his first knuckle. Animalistic, to chew on her bit like this. Once, only once, does he buck against her core. Taming her and taking pleasure in how wet she’s become from this alone; her lower lips split around him. “You can still make it up to her, can’t you?”

He feels her excitement huff hard against his thumb. Short and shallow panting.

“Tell her you’re sorry.”

Incoherent as she is as he suddenly shoves himself deeper into her throat, he catches it. The first vowel. Though the dark is lifting, the scant starlight conspiring to shine upon their tent, his vision blurs her body. Faint ringing infects his ears: the casualty of hearing Emilie’s name from Nathalie’s lips.

“Again,” he husks, leaning closer and absently grinding his sheathed cock against her underwear. Rougher than Emilie’s, who will guide his hand to her lower back during galas, galleries, press events, showing him with a wink her lack of panties. Whispering daydreams in his ear—*what if I kept you in me all night? Would everyone know?* Laughing, then, before leaning closer, making him flinch with need. *Leaking down my thighs. Who wouldn’t be jealous of you?*

“Tell her you need her,” he demands. Begs. “Tell her you’re nothing without her.”

Of course, she can’t. But he feels the words form anyway, clumsy around his thrusting. She’s so good, he marvels, when she tries for them, so he orders her again and again and once more, just to hear her struggle around him.

Gabriel removes his thumb, replacing it with one finger. Then two, when his better senses burn under his need to see her, hear her, *feel* her lost in bliss. Her lips wrap around the girth of him and she sucks back spit and fingers and half-words. Working her tongue between the split of his knuckles to tease the webbing in short little flicks as he continues.

“Do you think she forgives you?” he asks, pinning her head against their shared pillow with the meat of his palm against her jaw. Pulsing the base of cock against her entrance and keeping her at his mercy with his other hand. His underwear is tacky with so much cum, he feels like a teenager again. “Do you even want her to? Do you deserve it, Nathalie? Show her.”

Knuckles to her tonsils, Nathalie gags and still she craves more. His ring at her uvula and the sweat on the grooves of his fingerprints, the intact lifeline in his palm. Long life, two loves. Her nails clipped to nubs by her earlier frantic clawing, she paws at his wrist to take more of him, all of him. She garbles the title revered—*madam, madam, madam*—and Gabriel’s face flushes anew. The depths to which she’ll debase herself for Emilie the one thing he knows on a primal level, more than anything.

“Do you see her?”

His fingers find their home in the back of her throat. How her body tries and fails to eject him, spasming in order to make room for him. Allowing him in deeper the way she always will. This, the shape of her desire, vibrating every nerve in his hand.

“Are you hers?”

Affirmations he knows by rote distorted by his ruthless thrusting. Sticky spit coats his whole hand and his body shudders for more. The flame in him explodes to hear her so undone, so at his beck and call. When he asks again, gruff and bent over her as if threatening to crawl inside of her for the truth, a cry breaks past it all and he redoubles his efforts—another finger heavy on her tongue to keep her open, to keep her from forming anything but sobs.

“She can’t understand you. Tell her, Nathalie. Tell her.”

He could yank his hand out right now, clutch her jaw and use her gathered spit to rut against, flooding the planes of her face with his precum. The salt of her mixing with the salt of him.

His cock pulses from base to head, the vein fluttering his tip missing the bow of her lip.

She'd let him. She'd thank him. She'd drink him, latch on and suck as he goaded her just like this, more and more and more—

To her, Gabriel succumbs. His left hand rips away from her mouth to pull himself free, ignoring for the moment how she cries out in something like pain. Jagged edges of his untrimmed nails scrape sun-chapped skin and there's a surrender in his punched-out sigh as his cock slaps against her stomach. Sweet scratch of the hairs trailing down cradling the heat of him.

A twinge over the head of his cock has him chewing his bottom lip raw. He follows the urge, giving a few test thrusts against her. Fails to control a gasp as precum beads, then spurts as he begins to buck against her in earnest. For a moment, flashing in his mind, his own mess replaced with her tongue. Paints her greedily then: long, indulgent drags of his tip sliding his slick before slamming back onto her, sucking in through his teeth as he imagines her mouth around him, wet and patient and exactly as he pleases. Impotently, lost in his own mind, he brushes against the ring of her navel. Lets himself leak and spill into it the way he wants to ruin her cunt.

But Gabriel is a benevolent man, and Nathalie still hasn't come.

When he returns his attention to her, all of her visible to him now, he realizes she's begging between breaths. His wife's name has never sounded sweeter.

Gabriel arcs away from her, pulling his leg away and she, so trained and good, sways with his hands as he rips her briefs away. Opening herself wide, neither of them bothered by the way her hips pop. Both of them knowing how far she can bend herself in their name. Bared to him, she tries to show him the part of her worthy enough to be held down.

Before discarding it, Gabriel fists her briefs soaked through around his shaft. Pulsing his palm around his aching head and mingling, for a moment, the sum of their need.

"Tell her you want her."

She seems to wrestle with the words in her mouth. He jerks into the rough crotch of her briefs.

"Nathalie." So much warmth and salt in the air and on his tongue.

"Please," she says, softening. In the night half-lit with a side of the moon all theirs, he can see her lip quivering, her wrist digging into one of her eyes. Words failing like so much else. "I want… I don't know if I deserve…"

He throws her briefs to the side, his hands having better use, and collapses over her, his project half-finished. His left hand's middle and ring finger part over her mound and spread her.

“And why wouldn’t you deserve this?” he asks, moving to massage the sides of her clit. Squeezing it between his knuckles and feeling her swell over, swollen and requiring just the ghost of a touch.

The proof is this alone. The two of them, alone.

At home, Emilie, alone.

His middle finger drops down below, dipping into a strand of cum and glazing her clit with it. “You’ve done so well showing her you’re sorry. So good, Nathalie.”

Weakened, ready, Nathalie turns her head to whine into the crook of her elbow. Around the tip of his ring finger she flutters and he who knows he so well pushes in all at once.

Seeing her body seize: the arch of her back, her nails digging into her palm, the expression over her face—it nearly does him in. He reels back his hips as he drips more cum onto her thighs.

And then she clenches, trying to keep him in, and he folds like a house of cards.

He sets a brutal pace, adding another finger before she’s even able to properly form Emilie’s name. He turns his wrist and bumps his thumb against her clit, resting it for her to jerk against as he owns her cunt. They find a rhythm together as he impales her, again and again, down to the knot tied around his finger in a platinum band.

Nathalie’s walls suck him in deeper, as hungry for him as was her mouth. He wonders sometimes who it is that looks back at him. During meetings, during sex—she who is so empty, she who is so ready to take. Bottoming out in her never feels like enough; always something just beyond that she would give if he ever needed.

And Gabriel is a man who needs.

“Can you come for her?” he asks. Knowing by her cadence that she’s close. “If she wanted you?”

Nathalie bites back a yip and fails, a moan breaking open between them, joining the filthy sound of her making a mess of their sleeping bag.

“You know better than to make her wait, Nathalie.”

Her legs quiver and tense. His fingers are choked inside the tight seam of her cunt as she holds on for too long, ruining her own orgasms. Fleeing from pleasure.

Compassion crystallizes into determination as he forces another finger inside, thumb rubbing circles around her clit. The world around them holds its breath to hear her slick all the better, so wet that he’s fucking her own cum back into her, splashing it against his palm. He swallows back spit, eager to gag himself on the taste of her.

Confessed once under duress, while Emilie squeezed his base, thumb repeatedly petting his cleft and backing away at the first sign of cum, that he loves to eat Nathalie out until she’s

boneless, too tired to even say what to do next. Laying spread for him, he said, like she was made to be used and filled and fucked. Perhaps sleeping, he blurted, and just waiting for him, poised and perfect.

And that's when Emilie popped him into her mouth and sucked.

"I can't—" Nathalie cries, sounding lain to waste.

"You don't disobey her, Nathalie," he husks. "*Now.*"

The hours she teased herself, the roll of her hips she can't stop, his thumb bruising her clit—everything hones into this moment. Her orgasm shored up where his fingers penetrate once with precision, something *snaps* on his final thrust. She keens and pushes into his lap, his hand; the balls of her feet slipping against the sleeping bag as she gives herself to him fully. He keeps his pace steady and when he wets his bottom lip, eager to taste, Nathalie squirts onto his thighs, a stream licking the underside of his cock. His mouth pops open, too out of his mind for a moan. Impotently humping the air for more as she comes down from her high.

Reeling, Nathalie shakily drops back down against the robe, settling into herself like a house fire. Burnt to the frame and catching her breath in the dark. The only casualty Gabriel, who withdraws his hand and finally, *finally* gorges himself on her. Taking the salt-spray of her and sucking his fingers, pressing his nose to the well of his knuckles as he swallows her into his throat. Indulgent little smacks, making a show of it.

As he does this, he listens to her aftershocks: the pitched half-moans she tries to snuff out into the crook of her elbow, holding onto the last of her dream. Crying, he thinks, or about to, in the way he knows she needs to. Won't allow herself otherwise.

"She'd love seeing you like this," he says softly.

Painted with Emilie's cum, and wrecked by her hand, a mouth bruised pinks and reds—that's what Nathalie thinks of, but pure ownership swells in Gabriel. Knowing this—her whimpering, her body jolting as if shocked by the lightest touch—was all his doing. Release he gives her and his responsibility, this aftercare.

When Nathalie calms, she struggles to find her voice again. Her throat fucked to the raw tenderness earned by apologies, pleas, begs for forgiveness; arguments they have back at home between each other. Bedside sobs that sharpen the afternoon haze from oneiric to nightmarish; the despair that coats itself over every bone and every marrow until what hardens is a chrysalis to stop the pain.

A job well done, a face swollen with tears and all of her words said, though all she's coughed up are gagged and spit-logged cries for more.

She takes off the blindfold and blinks into the dark. Finding him, his gaze, immediately; somehow, always.

"Thank you," she rasps; words like hisses of ash. Her hand raises to rest on his neck hot and damp, her thumb petting his cheek cutting youth with grief, and he bends down to meet her

as she presses her forehead against his. Sharing, like most everything else, their breath as she continues to praise him until her words eke out threadbare.

“It took so much this time,” he comments. Rubbing circles with his thumbs over her stomach.

Nathalie hums, non-committal, and before Gabriel can press more her palm wraps around the head of his cock. He drops his head to the slope of her neck, grunting into her collarbone and nipping lightly at her skin.

“For you,” she says, sounding irrevocably cracked, “it’s taken so little."

Determined to win, he scoffs. “I’m not the one who denies myself—”

She pumps him once and he folds completely.

Working himself into her fist, Gabriel moves his left hand to cradle her face, pulling her into a clumsy kiss. She gasps into his wanting mouth, letting him use of her whatever he needs. Sucking at her bottom lip in desperate gulps. Reveling in the pain as he unknowingly bites at the blister forming like a whore’s stigmata; a pale imitation of vows, of a bride, of forever.

Nathalie winces, feeling all over again the pain of how his ring had caught on her lower lip before he lost himself grinding against her. A fact he’s missed in all of his ego and one she’s let him keep, if only to feel him shake and shiver and wrench out curses between sighs. Proof that he’s as gutted as she. Taking his ear between her teeth and pulling, an awful absence surrounding them—between them in bed, the space where earrings should puncture his lobes if they, the both of them, weren’t making a bed of failures.

Nathalie takes the hand at the back of her head and guides it to her neck and he, like always, understands. Collars her throat in his hands, tailor’s tape to tip. This is how you measure grief: how easily her body acquiesces, how she merely says *please* before adjusting his fingers herself. Breath, not blood, though he can take all he wants of both.

She’d let him. She’d thank him.

One sip of air before she dives back under, Nathalie does just that: croaks out a *thank you* before he enters her slow, tip to middle to hilt, then a little more with a snap of his hips and stealing the last bit of breath Nathalie kept. This is how you stop the bleeding, after all—fashion the tourniquet and tug.

His pace is sloppy, irregular, needy. Skin slaps skin and he feels her cum coating the hairs around his thighs, trickling down or smacking up against his lower abdomen clenching. Liquid pleasure tingling at his spine. Her throat under his grasp bears his lust as he squeezes and causes her to sputter. He watches her writhe, taking her in like a movie, the way her lungs pop like wings and how she throws her head to the side, *his* side of the bed, and fills her nose with him. Her hair clings to her forehead, her fringe flung in every direction.

She’s so warm around him it’s unreal. She’s so beautiful like this, it makes him dizzy. His fingers ache as he holds her down into the sleeping bag. Marking her, his scent all over her.

Her cunt tightens around him and he can't escape, can barely move back before he's slamming back into her; rutting, fucking, his climax curling low—

Divine intervention. He loosens his grip and her eyes shut tight as explodes into a coughing fit.

Like any good man, he breaks.

Her walls spasm around him, coaxing cum with every punched out groan of his wrecking through their tent, her cunt, his clenched teeth.

"Say it," he hisses, tears wetting his lashes as his nails brand her neck anew. Folding over her, their bodies forming the shape of a ring. "Say it; please, I'm sorry, everything, I'm—"

And Nathalie, good Nathalie, meeting him where he is. The most at home she's ever been in this body of hers: whispering words Emilie would say to him, if given more time. Hands abandoning the blanket to cradle his sullen head beading sweat.

Her sickness extracted and poised on her tongue, she brings the hot shell of his ear to her mouth and tells him, with her voice roughened to Emilie's sick tenor, that he's forgiven. Sweet like suckled honey, the medicine hidden under her tongue as he fills her mouth with his, searching and searching and searching. Can't pry her open enough, work himself deep enough as he comes inside. Flooding her like he wanted, like he needed.

Hard to say who is the life raft and who is the ocean. Both of them disappearing by the second like heatwaves on the horizon. Mirages, maybe, all of this dreaming.

Time unwinds itself around them, every second dissolving into their panting, their shifting, the errant moans.

"Isn't that better?" he asks at last into her neck, pressing kisses where bruises bloom like moonflowers. Pillowing her wounded skin between his gentle lips, the warmth of his own fervor bright on his lips. He repeats himself, blowing air against her overworked skin and her hands grasp at the short hairs of his nape, her legs caging him to continue leaking cum across her stomach.

"You do too much for me," he says. Clears his throat. Corrects, "For us."

For posterity, to cover his own shameful tracks. If he doesn't name it, this devotion she gives with her hands and on her knees, then it exists forever. His to keep, for better or for worse.

She laughs, in that half-delirious, half-bashful way that makes everything, for a split second, seem normal. Hands finding his, always, she noses his cheek and whispers, "I'd do anything you asked."

He hums, already knowing.

Nathalie's tremulous smile disguises her frown and something wells inside her. Kicks her diaphragm and has her struggling for breath between coughs splattering spit across his chest, steady and sure. Raking in air, Nathalie's head swims with it all—the guilt, the ruined body

he can make a home of, the words that seep past her lips like rain from the gutter. Pittering, pattering, pathetic.

Not enough. Not enough.

It's all she can repeat to herself, mantra of the guilty, as he cleans her with his tongue. Just what sticks to her thighs, the gutters of her hips, honey of his fingertips—but neither Gabriel nor Nathalie keep score of who asks first, who pulls first before she's kept open again by his two thumbs. Playing in the mess of her, stomach to cunt to mouth. Sucking and slurping until he's sloppy with her, chin shining and eyes smiling. All of her shaking and splitting in two and wanting, always wanting.

And when he asks if she needs more, there's no sweeter way to be loved, she thinks, than how his hand meets hers again at her neck and crushes it twice as tight. How resignation shreds his gutted sigh as he sinks to the bottom of her, sweet squelch of her cum sealing him at the base.

Her consciousness sparks and fizzles, creating an oblivion she can fall through as he imagines a new reality for her. Whispering in her ear or covering her mouth with his: here's where they live forever; here's where they've never left; here's where they're forgiven.

Both of them sipping the inevitable with each little death.

End Notes

“How many kisses have we crushed to our lips in prayer—only to pick up the pieces? If you must know, the best way to understand a man is with your teeth.”

here's to breaking the ice of 2026. something small, something a little new and nathalie, as always, borrowed and blue <3

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